Title: Understanding the Bible

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Why Study the Bible?

The most troubling question on the lips of the students is why they should study the Bible as a general course. The students often query what the Bible has to do with their respective disciplines in the university. They ask for instance what the Bible has got to do with my studying of Education, Law, Commerce and the list goes on. The Bible to them belongs elsewhere may be in the Faculty of Theology. The question can be broadened and be asked in regard to humanity in general. Why should anyone study the Bible?

The general feeling is that the Bible belongs to the Church. Therefore, when it is studied in a university like ours as a common course it is because the institution has a connection with the Church. The most extreme answer that I once got from an adult student is that the Bible belongs to children. This reasoning strikes a chord with the notion that religion belongs to the realm of those who are not fully emotionally developed.

Therefore, as the first question one needs to deal with is this fundamental question. What has the Bible to do with me as a person? Why should I read or study the Bible?

The answer to this question lies in the understanding of our own selves. Socrates once said that human beings are a measure unto themselves. The statement begs the question whether a human person is an end in himself. Human nature always appeals to a being higher than itself. The limitations in human nature points to an existence of a being higher than us. Human beings have had various references to this being over centuries.

Religion refers to this being as God. We read, for example, from both the Old and the New Testament that God is the creator of everything. In the first two chapters of the book of Genesis we learn that God created the heavens and the earth and all they contain (Gen $1^{11,21}$).

Human beings are therefore God's creatures. In these two accounts in the book of Genesis, they are, however, created in a more special way in relation to other creatures. They are created in the "image and likeness of God (Gen 1^{26} . ; 2^{7} and God breathed into his nostril life giving breath and man became a living being),They are further given dominion over other creatures Gen 1^{26}. While in Gen 2^{19} we read: "And God brought all creatures to man to see what name man will call them and that was their name." Human beings are finally mandated to be fruitful multiple and fill the earth (Gen 1^{28}).

It is important to understand what these expressions each means individually. What does it mean that we are made in the image and likeness of God. There is always an interpretation of the phrase to mean a physical resemblance. God is thus conceived as the model of humans. Humans are seen to be an exact copy of God (2 Kings 10^{10}). In Ex. 20^{4-6} and Deut. 5^{8-10} it is forbidden to make the image of God since nothing on earth resembles God. We, therefore, encounter a difficulty in perceiving human being as a physical stature of God. The expression that we are made in the image and likeness is, therefore, a figurative language which bears the same connotation as God breathing in human being enabling him become a living being.

The making of man in the image and likeness of God is a royal language. According to the surrounding cultural settings of the biblical times (ANE) kings were seen as images of God. They were the representatives of God. Hence the expression image and likeness of God is a reference to power sharing. Human beings are made as co-creators or co-partners with God. We are basically God's stewards here on earth. We take care of the earth on behalf of our creator. We acknowledge that all we are and have are gifts from our creator. The basic of the gifts is life itself. Hence to be good stewards we must seek the mind of God.

Stewardship entails two basic elements, i.e., accountability and management.

God is the master of human beings and his mind is found in his communication. The form of God's communication to humanity is found in the Bible. The Bible thus becomes the sacrament of God to us. In the Bible we encounter God's expectation for the humanity.

What, therefore, does it mean to be a steward? First and foremost we are stewards because all that we are and have is given to us. What we are and have are gifts. It is erroneous to hear people talk that "my life is mine I do with it what it pleases me". No person is an island entirely in

himself or herself. Life is itself the most fundamental gift God has given to us for ourselves for others (Acts 17:24-28). Stewardship entails certain characteristics.

Characteristics of a good steward

The most outstanding quality of a steward is faithfulness. It is rightly held that faithfulness is the best virtue in a relationship. Nothing is more noble, nothing more venerable than fidelity. Faithfulness and truth are the most sacred excellences and endowments of the human mind(Marcus Tullius Cicero). Faithfulness is truthfulness of oneself(Heb 2:17;3:2,5). God is faithful because he is true to his nature (Deut7:9).

We ought to be faithful in the service of the gifts or abilities we have been entrusted with (Mt 25:14-30). We live in the world where there is increasing emphasis on success than the means to the goal. People today judge more what a person has gained other than how one reached there. Over emphasis on success may lead to malpractices. There many who believe that the end justifies the means which runs contrary to the gospel values. It is the Lord who gives the harvest, ours is to faithfully plant. There is an urgent need for a change of paradigm where the emphasis is placed on the value of the seed as opposed to the harvest.

Another requirement of a good steward is always to be alert. The alertness entails a sense of preparedness. We must always be found with our accounts balanced (Lk 12 $^{35-48}$). The time of the master's return remains unknown. It means we must always be doing the intended will of the master.

Further as stewards, we are expected to be wise and making the best use our time. This is probably one of the greatest failures for human beings. We always think there is a tomorrow

which never comes (Eph 5^{15-16}). Humanity has time but the problem is how to fill in the hours. Our time on earth is meant for useful service. The service is rent we pay while here on earth. We must always keep it in mind that our span on earth is short so there is no moment to do evil.

A story is told of a senior devil who wanted to test the junior devil before commissioning them on earth. The question was a standard one, "What will you tell humankind once you reach down there?"

The replies were varied. The first answered, "I will tell them there is no God." This one sadly failed the exam because human beings though they could deny God deep down they know He is there.

The second replied, "There is no sin." Our human conscience tells us there is sin. We feel guilty whenever we wrong others, so this one too failed.

The third one replied, "I will tell humans worry less there is always time." Is this not the way we think? There is always time. The way we use our time is paramount in determining our stewardship. We must always keep it in mind that tomorrow never comes. In life there is no revision.

The Bible thus grounds us on real stewardship exposing the reader to what the master expects of a servant.

The other fundamental reason for reading the Bible also comes from our self understanding. Human beings are transcendental beings. We are open to transformation. We are growing towards perfection (Mat 5^{48}). Scriptures serve that purpose of delivering us to our ultimate destiny. We read in 2 Tim 3^{16-17}, "All Scripture is inspired by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in righteousness; so that the man of God may be adequate, equipped for every good work." Humanity has its final goal to be righteous (Mat 6^{25-34}; 1Tim6^{11-16}; 1Pet2^{24-25}). We only attained this goal when become reflection of God. In St. Paul's understanding we ought to be the word of God ringing out. It's on this account that Paul happily

proclaims its not I who lives but Christ who lives in me. To be human is ultimately to be divine. The Bible transforms us because it is a book of values.

Albert Einstein once noted that, it is not enough to teach people a specialty. Through it they may become a kind of useful machine, but not a harmoniously developed personality. It is essential that students acquire an understanding of and a lively feel for values. They must acquire the vivid sense of the beautiful and of moral goodness. Otherwise, they with their specialized knowledge more closely resemble a trained dog than a harmoniously developed person. They learn to understand the motives of human beings, their elusions and their sufferings in order to acquire proper relationship to individuals and the community.

This is a purpose best served by the Bible since it teaches on how to be at peace within ourselves, with other, and with God. It helps us acquire wholeness, that is, become complete human beings (Col 4^{12}). In our daily life we often make a distinction between the learned and the educated. One who's life is guided by the scriptures is an educated person since he is at one with his environment.

How does the Bible achieve this goal? It must be realized that the Bible is about real people and events. It thus depicts historical events that symbolically represent aspects and traits within us. It, therefore, gives us guidance and parameters within which to conduct our lives.

What is the Bible?

We can now answer the question what the Bible is. On the surface the question appears simple but the answers one gets lead us to see how important it is. What the Bible is, is an important question often asked but also variously answered.

The British Times Newspaper 1996 refers to the Bible as the world best seller that no one reader reads. This conception can be further stretched to the point that the Bible is viewed as the humanity's greatest treasure. It is the greatest literary work ever written. The greatness of the Bible can be judged by its influence on humanity throughout history.

The word Bible relates to Greek Τὰ βιβλία (*ta biblia)* which translates as "books". Basically we understand the Bible as a collection of writings. Therefore, we are often more acquainted with the definition of the Bible as a library of books. Soon we realize this definition is inadequate since the Bible is not simply any collection of writings.

The Bible is God's written communication to humanity. These are a collection of writings that contain God's message to people. Thus comprehensively we can talk of the Bible as pluralistic text, made up of many parts with many divergent views about God and his relations with the world.

This understanding of the Bible will help us for instance deal with frequent questions such as: How is the Bible the word of God? And do Christians have only one Bible?

The first question is directly relevant to the current discussion. The statement needs to be broadened to include the human element. The Bible is both the word of God and human word. It is the word of God in terms of the divine message it communicates. The divine communication to humans is expressed in human language which is determined in human circumstances and situations. The Bible, for example, written under Jewish culture predominately uses this cultural setting to pass its message. Hence the Bible becomes predominately male in its applications. It is for example the woman who fast sins. Paul tells the women not to speak in assemblies. The

combination of both the human and the divine elements is best mirrored in the doctrine of incarnation where Jesus combines both the divine and human nature.

The Bible takes after the nature of Jesus who was both divine and human. Jesus was God but to make himself more comprehensible he took upon himself our nature. The Bible in a like manner is God's instrument in expressing the divine will which can only best be understood through our languages.

It is therefore important when we read the Bible to always seek the message (meaning) behind the words used. We may ask for example what does it mean God rested on the Seventh day? The reading of the Bible must thus of necessity be a critical process. It is important to examine how we read and understand what we read in the Bible.

Therefore, one of the primary purposes for reading the Bible is to know what God expects of us as his stewards. God intends us to study his word but how to go about it is always a challenge. Key to the study of the Bible is its interpretation. There exists a legend that, "when the Holy One, blessed be He, gave the Torah to Israel, he gave it only in form of wheat, for us to make flour from it or flax, to make a garment from it." God depends on the community to fulfill the biblical meaning.

HOW TO READ THE BIBLE

Broadly speaking approaches to the Bible can be categorized into two, that is, academic and non academic approach. When we talk of academic, we are referring to the scholarly use of the Bible. Here we have in mind approaches like historical critical and literary critical approaches, while non academic readings are at times labeled spiritual or devotional approaches. However, it must be bore in mind that these two broad approaches are not necessarily mutually exclusive of each other. Both, for example, imply a critical reading of the Bible. Any meaningful reading of the Bible must be a critical reading. Again both are concerned with exposing the meaning of the text. The difference is on the emphasis.

The non academic approach is more concerned with the impact of the text on the reader. When a Pastor prepares his sermon his or her ultimate concern is what the audience learns from the text. Therefore, what is given Promise is the appropriation of the text.

Generally, even the non academic reading of the Bible is diverse in nature. Roughly we may categorize these readings into four groups: Historical, Inspirational, Literary and Theological.

Historical Approach

The historical reading of the Bible is also referred as the literal approach. Many people assume the chronological order of the events in the Bible. They take for granted that the manner the events are reported in the Bible is how they actually occurred. They read the Bible as a book of history. When the Bible says God created the earth for seven days it is literally so.

Such a reading misses the point, since the authors of the biblical text were not concerned with reporting things the way they actually happened but rather with their significance. They preferred to go with the meaning behind the events. This is the reason for instance we have in the same Bible two apparent contradictory stories of creation: Gen. 1:1 – 2:4a and 2:4b-25. "One would read a contradiction between the first and the second accounts of creation. When did God create human beings for example as the first or the last creature? Again how do you conceive God creating light on the first day and only later on the fourth day create the sources of light (such as moon and stars). Is it as often thought by some that God can afford to do whatever he likes? It has also been argued even of recent times that the Bible and science are incompatible.

These difficulties can best be resolved if we understand the intention of the biblical writers. These writers did not set out to write history for its own sake but rather the significance of it. The writer gives the importance or the meanings of the happenings?

Therefore, the creation story for example is not about creation itself, i.e., how God created, what he used, how long he took etc. It is about meanings. God is the author of all things in existence. He has shared this creative power with us human beings.

The effect of historical reading is that many people either despise the Bible as contradictory in nature or as fallacy, i.e., not telling the truth. On the contrary, the Bible is concerned with the ultimate truth, i.e., that which we can rely on for our salvation. Jesus becomes the ultimate truth that the Bible is concerned about (Mt 22:16; Joh14:6).

Therefore, the best way to conceive the Bible is that it is a story of salvation. Stories are generally told to convey meanings.

Inspirational Approach

This is another popular way in which many read the Bible. It is a motivational approach. One reads the Bible by situating the self in the state of the people of the biblical times. We so often come across expressions such as: "if the Lord did it then he can do it now." Ps. 23 are popularly sung by many to illicit such a reading. However, the greatest challenge with such a reading is that it can be very selective. It creates attention only to particular texts in the Bible, and in extreme cases those texts have been clearly marked in colours. The end effect is that it makes the reading of the Bible uncritical. We just assume and receive everything hook line and sinker. It is important to always bare in mind that the whole Bible speaks to us.

LITERARY APPROACH

Many a times students tell me that they read the Bible for entertainment just to enjoy the stories. In other words, they are reading the Bible like literature i.e. like a book of William Shakespeare or Chinua Achebe. No one would object that the Bible is a piece of literature. In fact, it is often termed the greatest literary work ever written. But the underlining question is: Is the Bible like any other literature?

The Bible is a religious literature. It is a confessional document. The Bible is an embodiment of a people's faith.

THEOLOGICAL APPROACH

We are here reminded of the word theology which comes from the two Greek words: *Theos*, meaning God and *Logos* for word or science. So basically it means the science of God. Theological approach is concerned with reading for meaning. The reader seeks to understand the meaning of certain things from the Bible. For example what does Bible say about issues like war, homosexuality, abortion etc. The question that arises out of this quest is whether the Bible has all the answers to all human questions.

The answer is indeed "Yes" but with a nuance. The Bible is basically about historical people and historical events. It is often said history repeats itself through circumstances that might be different. Though our situation may differ from those of biblical time, however, in the Bible find the parameters in which we can respond to our issues.

Theological reading, however, is not without its danger. Such an approach is open to business. History of the Bible informs us that the use of the Bible has been both positive and negative. We

know that evil such as slavery, apartheid and women oppression were supported on the basis of bias reading of the Bible.

We have so far outlined four readings of the Bible with their critique. It is apparent that there is need for a way forward. Hence the question is always asked: What is the best way to read the Bible? The best way must be a profitable reading of the Bible. It means therefore it must be a critical reading.

A critique reading must begin with our disposition. We ought to approach the Bible with an open eye, ears, heart and mind. This is an attitude open to learning. The opposite of this is twofold: the assumption that we already know everything about the Bible or that the Bible is too hard to comprehend. Great many fall under the former. But one teacher who set to test his students on the Bible knowledge asked where the famous saying "God helps those who help themselves is found in Bible." Of course various biblical texts were recited but none was correct.

Again we must read the Bible contextually. Many readers jump from verse to verse that suits them. Very often these verses are read out of context. The most important principle in interpretation is the context. There are generally many contexts of the Bible like sociological, literary and immediate context. The present or the immediate context of the text (what comes before and after) suffices for ordinary reading of the Bible. The knowledge of the context helps to avoid error and difficulties.

The reading becomes more profitable when the Bible is read with others in the community especially with those who belong to different aspirations than ours. It safeguards against our biases when we listen to different voices. This approach situates the Bible to its original setting which is the community.

Authorship and authors of the Bible

i) Authorship

Authorship of the Bible deals with the publication of the Bible. Jer. 36 provides great insight on how the writing of the Bible was done. The studying of the chapter reveals the following scheme.

The word originates from God. God then moves human beings to recognize his word for what it is. This is what is known as inspiration. A human person is convinced he is acting under the divine influence. Inspiration was not a one time event, it is an ongoing process. Today, this activity continues whenever we recognize God's word for what it is. Therefore as readers we are inspired depending on our dispositions.

Thus we have:

God – speaks the word

Prophet-receives the word and later dictates it to the secretary

Baruch -receives the word then writes it down

Text-it is not a definitive product, it is fluid, open to additions.

Destruction -does not mark the end of the text since there will be a production of a new text.

The destruction of the text by the king did not mark the end of the text but a new similar process was initiated resulting into a new text. The process represents the interpretation that resulted into the expansion of the text.

The communication from God to the Prophet and from the prophet to the secretary clearly shows the nature of God's word in its original stages. At the beginning the word of God was transmitted orally. The survival of this word depended solely on memory.

What do we know about memory? It is worthwhile mentioning a few. Memory is selective. People remember what they want to remember. It also changes that is to say our past memory gets interpreted in the light of the new experiences. The past memory gets a new outlook. Lastly, it is important to point out that our memory has a tendency of remembering things in brief. We do not recall every detail of the happenings.

The best illustration one can draw from the Bible of how the memory works are the gospels. We have four canonical gospels yet they are about the memory of one person Jesus Christ. All these gospels present different portraits of Jesus.

What we read in the Bible are valued remembrance of a people's experience with God. They involve the interaction of God's message with people's insights and questions. The oral word grew as people encountered new experiences and questions. We see clearly that even after writing took place the word was not fixed. The text continued to grow. This is clearly evidenced in the two existing texts of Jeremiah, a short version in the Septuagint and a longer one in the Hebrew Bible.

The process of writing involved writing, re-writing, editing and re-editing. There were changes in the Bible before it attained its final form as a canon.

We can therefore distinguish three levels of publication of the Bible.

1. Autonomous authors – these are writers who first committed the brief stories into writing. These include writers like the authors of the story of Saul and David and of the Prophetic autobiographical report.

2. Collectors – publishers who revised and actualized the existing and placed them in different light.
3. Redactors (editors) – writers who combined the existing writings while adding their own textual segments in the process. The Bible results from the work of redactors.

We thus observe that the publication of the Bible involved a wider spectrum. We have patrons, compilers and editors. This background can therefore clarify our understanding of the authors of the Bible.

ii) Authors of the Bible

Students generally assume they know who wrote the biblical books. They often take it for granted that the names given in the biblical writings are the actual authors. They will narrate certain figures and associate them with particular writings.

The Law of Moses – Moses

Psalm – David

Proverbs – Solomon

Mark – Mark

The question to ask is; are these really the authors of these books? Did Moses for example write the first five books of the Old Testament?

We need first to clarify the understanding of an author in biblical times and in the present time. Currently we perceive by an author as an originator of an idea. In the ancient near Eastern culture of which the Bible is part did not perceive authors in this modern sense. Authors were transmitters. They simply passed over what people had held, a people's treasure. Therefore, as it is the case with Bible writings in ancient times were anonymous. The names we find in the texts are to a greater extent attributions. The biblical books are attributed to figure heads. As a rule of the thumb the writers of the biblical books are unknown. There are few exceptions to this rule. In

the prophetic writing we can for instance link the autobiographical report to the prophet himself. In the New Testament we can associate Paul with letters like Romans, Galatians etc. While letters like 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus postdates Paul.

It was also an acceptable practice in the ancient cultures to write under someone's names. Disciples of a particular master continued to write under their master's name. We see evidence of this in the book of Prophet Isaiah. The book clearly has three distinct life spans. So we talk of first Isaiah 1-39, second Isaiah 40-55 and Third Isaiah 56-66. The argument to distinguish different authors in a given collection of writings or a particular book has its strength in considering differing style, language and even content. We can use the letters 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus in which we see a well structured hierarchical church. This Portrait is different from Paul's Church. So the writers of these letters depended on Paul's authority to sell their writings.

Another factor worth highlighting is that an individual book was not composed once and for all. The biblical text in its formative stages was open and fluid text. The text was often expanded through interpretations. The completion of an individual writing often lasted centuries. The text was written, re-written, edited and re-edited.

Hence the question, can we still talk of authors in the biblical sense? The answer is "Yes" but with a different contention. We talk of writers not as individuals but as group of writers. These writers as often identified on the basis of their language, style and tendencies.

When we read the Old Testament for example we talk of the following groupings:

The Yahwistic writers

The J writers or the Yahwistic writers – these are probably the first biblical writers. They are fond of using the personal name Yahweh for God. They are conceived to be naïve in their perception of God. Gen^{4b-25} is an example of a Yahwistic writing. The account begins by noting that, "When the Lord God made the heavens and the earth …" The expression Lord God is of importance. We realize that our translations we do not encounter the reference Yahweh. The name is often rendered Lord which is a title. So the account in the original Hebrew language

reads when Yahweh God … The author further pictures God as a human worker, he plants a garden, and makes human beings from the clay, God is therefore a porter. There is a remarkable difference in the understanding in the first story of creation in Gen 1^{1}-2^{4a}.

The Priestly writers

The other group of writers is the priestly writers or the P writers. Some of the striking characteristics of these writers is for example concern, for order, chronology, genealogy, numbers or ages, and the cultic laws. The book of number is a good demonstration of their work. We want to draw our example in the first creation story (Gen 1^{1}-2^{4a}). Creation is framed within a week; each event takes place within given day in six days. We are struck by the order in which things were created. On the seventh day is a rest day for God. The writer had in mind the Sabbath day which is a cultic observance. The Sabbath law, therefore, becomes ordained from creation.

The Deuteronomistic writers

We also talk of the Deuteronomistic or the D writers. These are the most influential writers of the Old Testament. We find their marks in many books of the Old Testament. The book of Deuteronomy best represents their work. They are artistic writers and often portray a characteristic of reformers. They advocated for the centralization of the cult, i.e., one God, One Nation and One Cult. The other emphasis of these writers is the land. The land is regarded both as a gift and a task.

The comparison of the Decalogue account in the Pentateuch will provide us with some insight into their thinking. We find the two versions in Ex 2^{1-17} and Deut 5^{6-22}. We will probably read the two versions and miss to see the differences. The Exodus version is a priestly product while the one in Deuteronomy is from a Deuteronomistic writer. In Exodus concerning the Sabbath the reason for the rest is based on creation. We can already see that two stories are linked together. In Deuteronomy the rest in effected because of slavery. The Israelites are urged to live on with a remembrance that once they were slaves. What does this mean? It is basically a call for them to oppose the enslavement of others and become liberators. Today's oppressed often become tomorrow's oppressors. This is the evil Deuteronomy warns against.

The Prophetic writers

We also have prophetic writers. They are responsible for the writing of the prophetic literature. The writers were generally the disciples of the prophets. The prophets themselves were basically speakers and most of the prophetic writings were done after them. The major prophetic concern was how the covenant between God and the people was being realized. Justice is the central issue of discussion in these writings. Biblical justice is a relational term that questions the manner we integrate with fellow persons and ultimately with God.

The apocalyptic writers

A closely associated with the prophetic writers are the apocalyptic writers. They are however deeply figurative in their language. The use of visionary language is from the background of these people. They come from the background of oppression and frustration originating from foreign rulers. They were influenced by the prophets, the wise, the priests and the scribes. Apocalyptic writers adopted the traditions of theses parties for their purpose. The focus of their communication is geared towards the end time. The best known apocalyptic writings are Daniel and Revelation. This literature goes beyond these two writings. We have, for example, presence of apocalyptic writing in Mk 13.

The wisdom writers

Among the authors are the wisdom writers. Wisdom writers were teachers of wisdom. Wisdom was meant to educate people into right living. It is the highest knowledge.

In the New Testament we find the same writers such as the ones for the gospels.

The Bible is therefore an end product of a long and a complex process. It involves many writers and various situations. Bible too is composed of variety of literary forms.

DIVISIONS WITHIN THE BIBLE

The treatment of the divisions within the bible is closely related to the question, what is the Bible?

The root derivative for the word Bible is from the Greek word, Ta BIBLIA, which is a plural for the books. Therefore, the Bible has best been understood as a library of books. Apart from the Bible having many books, it is also composed of various literary genres. The Bible contains different types of literature for example; the laws, Proverbial, Materials, Parables and maxims of Jesus etc.

We can, therefore, conceive of the Bible as a pluralistic text with many parts dealing with God's relation to the world. We are all aware of the two major divisions within the Bible, that is, the Old and the New Testaments.

This division begs a question, why the Old and New? The division has had its problems. There have been suggestions to talk for instance of the first and the second Testament or the Hebrew and the Greek bibles. All these divisions have got their problems. We remain with the question, what is the name?

The reference Old Testament has its origin in Christianity. It is Christians who first called this first part of the Bible the Old Testament. They considered themselves as participants in the New Covenant inaugurated by Jesus. (Jer 31:31, Mt. 26:28, Mk 14:24, Lk 22:20 and 1 Cor 11:25.

Hence the term Old Testament/Covenant is a reference to a collection of books inherited from Judaism.

How did the Jews refer to their sacred collection?

This collection had no single reference among the Jews. They had varied reference. It was called at times the Law and the Prophets (Mt 5:17, 11:13, Lk 16:16). The Law of Moses, the Prophets and the Psalms (Lk 24:44), The Law (Jh 8:5). The scripture (Rom 43, Gal.38) or the sacred scripture (Rom 1:2). Other references are from without the Bible, these include Miqra – which means **the** reading or that which is recited. The reference draws from the practices because the Scriptures used to be read out **while** people listened. Another reference is the **TaNaK**.

The **TaNaK** stands for a threefold division of the Hebrew Bible.

The Hebrew Bible

We can divide the Hebrew bible into three parts designated by letters T, N and K.

T is the Torah. This is the core or the most central part of the Hebrew Bible. It consists of the first five books of the Bible (Gen - Deut). It is referred to as the Law books of Moses. The reference is indicative of its content because these books largely consist of Law. There are a variety of laws found in this corpus. Moses is traditionally **associated** with the reception of the Law. He is the lawgiver hence the connotation the law books of Moses. In the Greek Bible, this corpus is called the Pentateuch, meaning the five containers.

The N stands for the *Nebium* (Prophets). The Prophets are taken as interpreting the Law. Hence it is second to the Law in order of importance. The Hebrew bible divided the Prophets into two, former and latter. The former Prophets include books like Joshua, Judges, Samuel and Kings. People question the designation of these books as prophetic. We need to understand the nature of Israelites prophecy. A prophet was a heir and critic of his tradition. He was basically a person of his time who attempted to discern the will of God for the present time. It is in this larger sense of the prophets that these books fit.

The latter prophets fall in what we generally consider prophetic. These are the three of the four prophets tagged the Major Prophets (Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Isaiah). The others are the so called the Minor Prophets or the twelve. (Hosea, Amos, Joel, Micah, Jonah etc. Daniel was not regarded as a prophetic writer.

K is the *Kethubim* (the writings). It is the least in order of importance regarded as interpretation of the prophets. The literature here includes Psalms, Proverbs, Job, Daniel, Ezra etc. This collection comprises of 39 books.

We need to ask how many books make the Old Testament. The answer is, it depends: when we talk of the Old Testament we have the Hebrew Bible and the Greek Bible.

THE GREEK BIBLE

It is the "Translation" of the Hebrew Bible into Greek. It is abbreviated as the LXX or the Septuagint. The story behind it is that it was translated by 70 elders who all agreed on the translation.

Septuagint formed the first Christian scriptures until the time of Christian reformation when Luther rejected it. What prompted this rejection?

Translations by their nature are suspect. They are normal interpretations of the original text. It is in vain that Muslims do not take any translation as a Quran. A Quran must be in Arabic.

There are marked differences between the Hebrew Bible and the Greek one.

One such obvious difference is in the language. The Hebrew Bible is composed in Hebrew while in Greek each language definitely has a philosophy behind it.

The second difference is in the division. We divide the Hebrew Bible into three parts while the Greek is fourfold: The Law, Historical, Prophetic and Poetic writings.

The Law is like in the Hebrew Bible. The historical books narrate history of Israel from the perspective of a Deuteronomistic writer. This history is therefore called Deutronomistic history. There is a cycle within the history where Israel falls into sin, follows a punishment, repentance and then God's pardon. This collection includes books like Joshua, Judges, Samuel and Kings.

The LXX further differs from the Hebrew Bible in that it includes Daniel among the Prophetic writings. We, therefore, come to have four Major Prophets that is Daniel, Isaiah, Jeremiah and Ezekiel. The distinction between major and minor prophets is purely determined on the length of the book. There are twelve minor prophets whose works were contained in a single manuscript.

Length of the Bible is another matter of divergence. The Hebrew Bible is shorter than the Greek one. This is because the Greek Bible has about seven additional books. Examples of such books include 1&2 Maccabees, Tobit, Sirach, Judith and Wisdom. These books have their influence in the Greek culture.

The book of Jeremiah is shorter in the Greek Bible than in the Hebrew Bible. This raises question on which version is older, Hebrew or Greek?

These differences have resulted in use of some terminologies. The major concerns here are the apocrypha, Deutero-canonical and Catholic and non Catholic Bibles. The word apocrypha basically means writing with hidden meaning. However, the specific application is dependent on religious affiliation.

The Protestants understand by apocrypha those additional writings found the Greek Bible like Tobit. They are saying these writings are good for reading but are not inspired. The Catholics do not include these books among the apocrypha. The Catholic notion of apocryphal writings consists of books that originally grew together with the current Biblical books but were not accepted finally in the listings. In the New Testament, for example, we have a couple of Gospels that were never accepted like Judas, Thomas, etc. In the Old Testament we have books like Enoch and Jubilee.

Deuterocanonical – is a term employed by the Catholics to refer to the seven additional books found in the Greek Bible. They admit that the 39 books in Hebrew Bible from the first canon and the extra seven are the second canon.

The Catholic Bible contains extra seven books. It is patterned on the Greek Bible while the non Catholic Bible follow the Hebrew Bible. They contain 39 books.

Therefore, when we talk of the Old Testament we have two canons. These are the Palestinian Canon, i.e., the Hebrew Bible and the Alexandarian canon which is the Greek Bible. This brings us to the discussion about a canon.

CANON

Basically the word canon means a measuring stick or rod. It is something used for setting the standard. Canon can also mean a norm or rule.

When we use it in reference for a book, we mean by its documents that are considered as authoritative for religious teaching and practices and the said authority last for generations.

Biblically the term canon can be viewed from two perspectives. It either refers to document considered to be divinely inspired. These documents are considered to have been written under the influence of the Holy Spirit. The Authors used human situation circumstances and situations. The effect is that the resultant text is both inspired and inspiring. This is what enables the Bible to be a transforming tool.

Or documents determined as being definitely closed and a defined collection. We can neither add nor subtract from this collection. This is also a specific collection known already to the readers. We cannot substitute anything within the Bible.

The question is how was such a collection determined? It was through a process known as canonization

CANONISATION

Recently we are hearing the word a lot with regard to two people in East African region (the late Cardinal Otunga Maurice and the Late Julius Nyerere). It is recognition that, first and foremost, they were ordinary people. Then above that they lived an extra ordinary life that is exemplary for human kind. So they become examples of life well lived.

Canonisation of the Bible was not an instantaneous event. It was a gradual and slow process that lasted many years. The shape of the books was not decided in one sitting. Another aspect of

canonization is that it was selective process. Many books were in circulation but only a number were acknowledged and inspired.

How then did this happen?

Canonisation is basically an inter change between faith community and authoritive writings. After the writing process was complete, many documents that originated from the oral tradition were given back to community. The faith community read them, others they approved and some they rejected. Faith community was the decider of which books became canonical. It depended basically on how they understood them. Certain books now in the canon because of the nature of their writings proved problematic to be accepted within the canon. These books included such documents like Daniel and Ezekiel. So it is basically a process from below rather than from above. It is not the Clergy who decided on the books. The subsequent councils only approved what the faith community had accepted. It was not clear when this process began but most likely when these books became recognized as God's word. Besides the faith consideration there were other issues that were looked into. There were, for instance, four criteria for the acceptance of the books of the Old Testament.

Criteria for Old Testament Books:-

1. The document must have its roots in reliable priestly tradition. There were many priestly families in Israel and some with dubious origin.

2. The document must have its root in reliable prophetic revelation. The basic question was how do we know that it is the Lord who has spoken? In Israel there co-existed false and true Prophets. It was always not easy to distinguish between the two. The only sure way was through knowing God's word of a true prophet must match the moral will of God.

3. The document must have been in cultic use. This applied mostly in form of songs. These songs must have been used in worship. The greatest hymn book in the Bible is the Psalms it contains about 150 songs.

4. The document must have a bearing to wisdom. Wisdom was considered within a faith perspective in Israel. It was seen as coming from God. (Job 28:28)

In some cases like in the New Testament we talk of two major canons. The question is what about the New Testament

THE CANON OF THE NEW TESTAMENT

Can we talk of a single canon for the New Testament? The answer is a big No. History has revealed to us the existence of many other canons other than the one we are familiar with. There are for example the existence of Marcion, Muratorian and the one accepted by Eusebius. Is it categorical that there is such thing as a universally accepted canon i.e., be it for the New Testament or the Old Testament?

Many Christians assume that the 27 documents in the New Testament are accepted over board. Luther rejected two of this collection among them Revelation and Jude. He maintains that these documents contain the Catholic doctrine of purgatory hence they cannot be inspired. The Orthodox for their part they have additional eight documents in this collection. An example of such inclusion are the Letters of Clement.

There are two basic considerations for the acceptance of these documents into the canon.

The criteria for the New Testament:-

1. Apostolic Linkage: The document must have a link with an apostle. The Gospel of Luke is linked to Paul, Mathew to Levi the tax collector, Mark to Peter and John to the beloved disciple.
2. Ecclesial linkage: The Church must have considered it as useful for its teaching on faith. It explains why a Gospel like Thomas was rejected because of it's over emphasis on the humanity of Jesus. The Church has always taught that Jesus was both human and divine. The other aspect is that the document must have been written early on. Late documents were not accepted.

Transmission and Translations of the Bible: Old Testament

The question the readers of the Bible often ask is, which one is the best Bible? This is a complex question because we need to understand the purpose of the reader. People may read the Bible for either spiritual nourishment or for academic endeavor. A reader may therefore require a different version to use.

A keen reading of the Bible points to alternative readings in some texts (Mk 1:1 ;16:8). This is evidence that there existed differing manuscripts. A Bible with textual notes at the end of the text testify to the existence of these variant readings.

The process that has given us the biblical text that we have received is a long one. Transmission began when the oral words were finally put into writing. There are three languages were basically used: Hebrew, Greek and Aramaic. Much of the original text of the Old Testament was written in Hebrew. We too have books that were original written in Greek what we have referred to as apocryphal writings or Deuterocanonical books. There is evidence that Aramaic was also used in texts like Daniel. The New Testament was wholly a Greek text though there are debates whether the gospel of Mathew was originally composed in Hebrew, Aramaic or Greek?

Understanding of the transmission of the Bible will help the reader avoid some fundamentalism about the text. The reader, for example, will understand that the text has changed over time as the text was copied out. It will open up the reader to read wholly and critically. The reader will pay attention to textual apparatus.

Beginners in the studies of the Bible think that the Bible they posses come from the original manuscript, which is not the case. The original manuscripts are lost and our Bible emanate from late manuscripts. This is very understandable because the Palestinian climate was not conducive for the preservation of the materials like papyrus and leather on which the writing was done for such a long time.

The primary text used in formal study of the Old Testament is the so called Massoretic text (MT) which dates from the 2nd century CE. Massoretic text is called so because the text owes it origin from a group of writers know as the Massoretes. The word is derived from the Hebrew word Massora which means tradition or transmission.

The original Hebrew text was a consonantal text or unprinted text. It was written with vowels. It is a difficult text to read and pronounce. The reading was done from memory. Hence with the increasing need for new texts there were distortions in the subsequent texts. Therefore, there arose a need to stabilize the text.

This need promoted the Massoretes to introduce the vowel points in the Hebrew text. The Massoretic text is therefore a text with vowels. The function of the Massoretes consisted of the following:

- Establishing an authentic consonantal text because there were already many variants of texts in circulation
- Supplying the consonantal text with vowel points and accents
- Added hand written commentaries on the side columns and at the ending of each book

We credit these people with the stabilization of the Hebrew Bible. The way we read the Hebrew Bible today stems from the Massoretes.

The existing old manuscripts of the MT are the Codex Lenigradensis (L) dating about 1009 CE. The codex L contains the whole of the Old Testament. This codex is today found in Russia in St. Petersburg. The other manuscript is Codex Allepo (A). It includes everything except the Pentateuch. The codex is kept in Jerusalem. These two texts represent the received text of Massoretic texts. The Old Testament that we read is based on the MT. It is regarded as the standard text.

There are, however, two other Hebrew texts that we can study to shed light to this generally acknowledged standard text. These texts include the Dead Sea scrolls/Qumran documents and the Samaritan Pentateuch.

The Samaritan Pentateuch (Sam P) contains the sacred scriptures of the Samaritans – a sect dating from the second temple period (i.e. 500 BC to 100 CE) which split from Judaism. The Sam P dates about 2nd – 1st Century BCE. There are a number of Sam P variants that contains older and more original readings than the MT. The Sam P bears special characteristics. Large number of variants is brought about by harmonization or revision of texts to make them run smoothly.

In Ex 14:11-12 for example the MT mentions a protest which does not appear in Sam P. Sam P adds something about the Israelite complaining to Moses in Ex 6:9 to make the reading smooth.

The Qumran documents: the excavation of the caves of Qumran, i.e., a location near the Dead Sea in Massada in 1947 yielded a textual witness in form of the Qumran documents.

The Qumran documents have both fragments and complete roll of almost all the biblical books. Most fragments date from 1st Century BCE – 1st Century CE. The importance of these fragments is two fold:

- It is a more closer to the original texts;
- It indicates that a multiplicity of texts existed in the century before the common era.

The presence of these other textual witnesses leads us to conclude that the MT is simply one witness of a textual form which was around in the 4th – 3rd century BCE.

Non Hebrew Textual Forms

A number of other ancients texts that are useful in tracing the origin of variant readings which differ from MT are in translations. These ancient translations are known as versions. The most important ones are; Septuagint (LXX); Syriac translation); Targum (Aramaic translation) Vulgate (Latin translation).

The Septuagint (LXX) it is the most important translation of the Hebrew Bible. The myth that surrounds it is that 72 Jewish scholars were responsible for its translation. There are suggestions that the place was in Alexandria in Egypt. The translation was done at different periods from 3rd to 1st century BCE.

Syriac translation: this is a translation from Hebrew to Syriac language. It dates from the 2nd century CE. The translation differs from LXX.

Targum translation: this is a translation from Hebrew to Aramaic for Jews who were in Palestine and Babylon from the end of the 6th century BCE onwards. Targum usually follows the MT but there are variations between the two.

Vulgate: it is the Latin translation from Hebrew. Vulgate is a unique translation since it is a one man translation. Jerome translated it between 390-406 CE. It is not a perfect translation since it has Christian orientation. Prior to it the Christians in North Africa had used Vetus Latina – a translation form 2nd – 3rd century CE based on the text of the LXX.

The importance of this discussion is helping one understand the nature of the text we are reading. At certain points in the text of the Bible we find letters like a, b and so. These letters are explained at the end of the text. The understanding of these notes safeguards us against fundamentalism in biblical studies. A good standard Bible suffices to illustrate what we have discussed here.

The Transmission of the New Testament

The original New Testament Greek text was written in capital letters without spacing. It is known as the **uncials**. The upper and lower cases came only later and that is the **minuscules**. Eventually, copying of the New Testament produced textual variants. It is estimated that over 2500 textual witnesses exist for the New Testament. These texts often do not agree. These texts are grouped into three text types. Texts fall into types owing to nature of how they were copied. As far as we can tell, most or all of the earliest copies were done in what is called a free style. People copied liberally ,perhaps correcting what they saw as mistakes ,and even adding comments

in the appear to fall Into the third category of strict copies. Strict copies ,like their name suggests,have little copying would become more common as time passed.copying freely and then more

strictly tended to produce local variations in the text. Each text types preserves certain variants in the text,and as even more time passed.

In contrast to the Old Testament where we have a representative for the whole text, the New Testament is made from many different manuscripts. The Old Testament is therefore rightly referred to as a diplomatic text and the New Testament as the eclectic text.

WHAT IS THE NEW TESTAMENT

In the New Testament Jesus becomes the point of focus Heb 1:1-3. Jesus is the definitive point of salvation history Acts 4:12. We have twenty seven different writings that differently express the view of Jesus Christ.

These documents are often either grouped in four or three divisions/categories. We will follow a three fold division.

1. Historical writings. These consists of the four canonical gospels, i.e., Mathew, Mark, Luke and John and the Acts of the apostles. We classify the gospels as historical because, in a several term they are about the "history" of Jesus while the Acts are about the "history" of the early church.

   Mark is the earliest gospel to be written (ca 68-70). Mathew and Luke relied on Mark as a primary source. Hence these gospels share similar characteristics like the same world view, language and the framework. In these gospels for example Jesus ministry is a journey that begins in Galilee and ends in Jerusalem. These three gospels are known as the synoptic gospels. They can be general be viewed together in a comparable way.

   However it must not be forgotten that there are distinctive emphasizes in each gospel. Mark, for example, emphasizes on the need for the Christians to expect suffering. It can rightly to

called good news in hard times. The Christians were facing persecution (Mk 13:9). The Christians are urged to always keep watch.

Mathew is the most favoured gospel by the Church. It is the only gospel that explicitly mentions the word Church. The gospel greatly emphasizes the community life (Mt. 18).

Luke emphasizes the universality of the Jesus' message in a remarkable way. Jesus is descendant of Adam, the first human parent (Lk 3:38 ; cf Mt1:1).

The Acts of the Apostles is a continuation of Luke's gospel (1 $^{1-5}$). It is the second volume and the gospel is the first. The gospel proclaims salvation to all while act points to the realization of this reality. It is a fulfillment of the proclamation.

John is considered as a supplement gospel. It elaborates on issues concerning Jesus in a deeper level. It is, therefore, designated as a highly theological gospel.

2. **Didactical Writings**

Didactical writings are mainly letters or epistles. The letters are twofold; the ones that are addressed to particular communities or persons. This type of letters composes the Pauline letters. The other grouping is the General or Apostolic letters. The general letters possess a universal character, that is to say, they were not directed to specific church community. Therefore, they are rightly called Catholic Epistles.

The Pauline letters are 13. These letters include: Romans, 1 Corinthians, 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1 Thessalonians, 2 Thessalonians, 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, Titus and Philemon.

Paul tends to model his letters on the ancient form of Greek letter writing. Therefore, a reading of Paul's letters exhibits a particular format or pattern. The Pauline format is threefold.

1. We have an introduction. The introduction has two part

    a) Salutation or greetings. Here Paul mentions the sender(s) and the recipients

    b) Thanksgiving. Paul commends the Christian community for the good they have done.

In our reading of the letter to 1 Thessalonians (the first Christian document ever written) 1 Thess 1 [1] is a greeting.

Who do we see as the senders of this letter?

Paul, Timothy and Silas are listed as the senders. These three can be understood as the authors of this letter.

Paul greets the community with a message of Grace and Peace. This is a popular pauline greeting formulation. What does Paul mean with these two words.

Grace (*charis*) is that gift from God that is underserved, it is a free favour which ultimately leads to salvation.

Peace (*Shalom*) is the most talked about aspect. Generally people see peace as the absence of war. The biblical peace runs much deeper. It denotes a totality or wholeness of relationship. It is an integrity of one's health, one's relationship with neighbour and God.

After greetings Paul moves to the thanksgiving. 1 Thess 1 2-10 is a thanksgiving.

What does Paul thank this community for?

Paul thanks them for three virtues (faith, love and hope).

Faith –it is a commitment to Christ and all that he stands for. Paul greatly emphases the aspect of faith throughout his letters. It is the greatest gift of God to humanity. It is brought about by God's saving power (Rom 3:24-26). Faith is what leads us ultimately to our salvation.

It is humanity's profound response of God's initiative recognized in his word and saving interventions.

This response means an intelligent adherence. St. Augustine rightly puts it that faith must seek understanding. Biblically faith implies trust and truth. It is an absolute trust in the living and true God, a dependence exclusively on him and loving obedience. (Rom 15, 6;17, 2 Cor 104, 1 Thes 1:6, 2 Thes 18).

Christian faith has three dimensions. **Belief conviction:** It is a conviction in certain truths or doctrines. We, for example, believe that Christ will come again at the end of time.

Trusting Relationship: The Kingdom of God is a calling to a relationship of unbounded trust in the faithfulness of God and in the power of God's saving grace expressed through prayer. In the Old Testament there are people trusting in the promises of God. (Mk 11:22-23).

Life of Love or doing: Life of loving calls for engagement in the world. It is not for the sake of individual but for the good of humanity. Living faith is found in doing (James 2:14-18, 24,26). Faith is active through love and produces the delighted trusts of charity (Rom 8:14, 1Cor. 6:9-11, Gal. 5:25, 6:8). Jesus thus notes that it is not those who call me Lord Lord but those who do my will that will be saved. A good tree ends up being known by its fruits. As the people of God our Gospel ought to be seen in the life we live. It is no longer I who lives but Christ who lives in me. What distinguished the early Christians from the rest was in the manner they lived.

Love – this is a service we offer to others. It is best translated as charity.

Hope –it is a confidence that the Lord will come. Hope helps us to endure the trials of this present life.

The thanksgiving can provide clues to what Paul will discuss in the body of the letter.

2. **Body**

Here Paul discusses the problems that were troubling particular communities. Paul's letters are situational or occassional writings. They rose out of particular situations affecting communities Paul had founded. These letters were answers to question Paul was being asked or issues that he over heared. 1 Thes 2^{1} -5^{11} is an example of the body of the letter. Some of the issues discussed include love as a characteristic of Christian life. It is meant to be shown for each other and even those outside 1 Thes 4 $^{9-10}$. The other issue regards sexual morality. Paul insists that the only appropriate place for sexual activity was in marriage. Sexual issues are predominantly addressed in the letters of Paul. In his letter to the Corinthians, Paul tells the Christians at Corinth that they cannot go and buy sex from the Prostitutes in the Seaport (1 Cor 6 $^{12-20}$). Christians should be opposed to the homosexual behaviour since it is a perversion of God's natural order (Rom 1 $^{26-27}$).

Knowing the situation Paul is writing from is key to understanding his writings. We must also make distinction between what is said that was time bound, that is, what was meant for that particular time and what he recommends for all the time. The wearing of veil for example or women speaking in church assemblies was for only a particular time.

3. **Conclusion**

Paul ends his letters with a benediction, i.e., a short of blessing 1 Thess 5 12-26.

The major exception to this format is the letter to the Galatians. Paul moves straight from the greetings to the body. It has no thanksgiving. This tells us the kind of community it was.

One may ask whether Paul wrote all these letters. I want to broaden the question further whether these are the only letters Paul wrote.

Today we know Paul wrote more letters that we no longer have. Paul most likely wrote four letters for instance to the community in Corinth. We today have only two.

The 13 letters attributed to Paul are classified in three categories.

1. Genuinely Paul or authentically Paul. These are letters that no one doubts Paul's authorship. They are seven in total. These include: Roman, 1 & 2 Corinthian, 1 Thessalonians, Galatians, Philippians and Philemon.

2. Doubtfully Paul. In these letters questions are raised whether Paul wrote them or not. The arguments are generally based on language and content to some extend. These letters are: Ephesians, Colossians, 2 Thessalonians. The first two are very similar in content.

3. Not Paul: these letters were certainly not written by Paul. The situations discussed in the letters reflect a period long after Paul had died. These letters are 1 & 2 Timothy and Titus.

These letters give Christianity both its foundation and character. They are the earliest ever written Christian documents and make about a third of the New Testament.

Bible as a Piece of Literature

The Bible has been described as the greatest piece of literature ever written. The question that this statement evokes in the reader's mind is what do you mean by labeling the Bible as literature?

The Bible is a text shaped by use of language. We, for example, list a number of literary forms as: myths, legends, songs, proverbs, sermons, letters etc. These are examples of general forms of literary expression. We can talk of two classifications of these forms, i.e., poetry and prose.

The focus of this section will be on the Old Testament. The Old Testament will be treated as represent text for the whole Bible.

The Literary Genres of the Bible

The biblical genre is so diverse. We find for example songs, laws, letters. Proverbs, sermons etc in the Bible. Despite of the diversity the literature can be grouped into two, i.e., poetry and prose. Both poetry and prose co-exist side by side in the Bible. Virtually half of the Bible is a poetic text. We can for example mention the Psalms, Lamentations, the Song of Songs, book of Proverbs etc. the question is the distinction between the two.

i) Poetry

There are certain characteristics that distinguish poetry from prose. The most significant characteristic of the Hebrew poetry is the use of parallelism. The word parallelism reminds us of our Mathematics class where we learnt about parallel lines. The concept revolves around two items. When we apply it to language we are talking about a repetition.

In Hebrew poetry we identify four kinds of repetitions/parallelisms.

i) Repetitive (synonyms) parallelism

ii) Adversative (antithetical) parallelism

iii) Complementary (synthetic) parallelism

iv) Climatic (ontological) parallelism

Synonymous parallelism is formed when two clauses expression the same idea but using different words. The second verse or line repeats the thoughts of the first while using different terminologies. We have here example like Ps 24:1-6 or Lk 12: 22-23.

In antithetical parallelism the second line says the opposite of the first. The contrast is effected by placing positive and negative expressions side by side. We see this for instance in Ps 37:16-17 or Mt 7: 17-18.

Synthetic parallelism is a situation where the second verse supplements the first. The second verse flows as a continuing logical extension of the thought of the first verse for example Ps 51:14-15 or Mt 23: 6-7. Ontological – the second line goes beyond the first in climactic manner. This is generally reached through repeating of a word or several words from the first. The case in point is for instance in Ps 29:1 or Mt 10:40.

Hebrew poetry also employs the use of images. These images bear witness to a personification of natural elements. We have examples of streams clapping their hands and mountains that rejoice Ps 98:8. We also read about the personification of the son in Ps 19 6-7.

It also uses metaphors and similes. These are both figures of comparison that bear witness to the energetic imagination of the poets of Ancient Israel (Ps 23:117; Ps 1:3-4 etc). Among other things, Hebrew poetry is full of rhyme and rhythm. This aspect is unfortunately lost in the translations.

Poetry in the Old Testament can be categorized either as profane or religious.

Profane Poetry

At first sight most student are taken a batch by the mention of something profane in the Bible. Remember recently in China there are attempts to index the Bible on the ground of sexual overtones. When we talk about profane we mean literature that had their original setting in secular surroundings. Most readers will have no problem singling out the Song of Songs.

However, it must be noted that an absolute distinction between profane and religious poetry remains an impossible task. Most profane literature have gained religious overtones, for example, the nationalistic song of Deborah (Jud 5).

We can point out some examples of profane poetry.

The so called Song of the Well (Num 21:17-18).

The poet summons the well to provide water a new. This was a common practice in ancient world when a well dried up, feasts were held to stimulate a restoration of the water flow.

The Song of Revenge (Gen 4 23-24).

Lamech prides himself of his unconstrained bloodlust. This is completely strange among the Israelites.

Mockery songs: these were either political or religious. They were sang upon the realization of victory (Judy 527-30). The religious mocking songs focused generally on the importance of idols (Jer 10:30-5).

Hebrew profane poetry also includes proverb, a sort of adage or short saying (Ez. 18:2 or Jer 31 :29).

We may also include the riddle in this grouping (Judg 14: 12-18). This riddle read like the story of Lwanda Magere (the famous Luo Hero).

In sum, we may conclude that the Old Testament both preserved and transmitted profane poetry.

Religious Poetry

Religious poetry is of greater significance than the profane poetry in the Old Testament. The latter is largely dependent on the former.

A distinction can be made in the context of religious poetry in terms of proverbs and songs. Proverbs are generally short expressions of ethical or religious character.

A proverb can be of different nature, i.e. priestly, wisdom, and prophetic in nature. Priestly proverbs are responses given by priests to requests or consultations cf. 1 Sam 23: 9-12; Haggai 2 12-14, Ps 24 3-5.

Prophetic proverbs are related to priestly one. It is different to draw a distinction between the two. It can be assumed that while the priestly instruction was associated with cultic occasions (Heb 2:11-13) the prophetic word had more to do with political matters (1 Kgs 22:5 ff.; Jer. 28; Micah 3:11). The prophets frequently make us of the formula. Thus say Yhwh or the words of Yhwh.

Wisdom sayings were aimed at a positive participation in social life and a judicious organization of individual existence. These sayings are normally fixed and pointed to the content to provide their teachings with a degree of authority and influence. It also made them easy to remember (Qoh 12:11).

Original the proverb consisted of a verse (Prov. 26: 7-9, 11).

Proverbs are a kin to riddles. The ability to solve a proverb and riddle was seen as an elevated form of wisdom.

Proverbs, however, developed from short forms to longer forms of teaching through additions gained in experiential testimonies (Prov. 7:6 ff; 24:30-34).

Religious song occurs frequently in the Old Testament. Music was part and parcel of an Israelite's life. However, we can distinguish the following backgrounds for songs; prophetic preaching, cultic circles and lives of individuals.

We can generally identify several types of songs that include hymns of praise, thanksgiving songs, lament songs, penitential and didactic songs. Examples of these are spread all over the Old Testament.

The most frequently represented of these songs are those of praise. These songs land the magnificence and majesty of Yhwh. The essential elements in the songs include the call to praise God and the reason why this praise should be done (Ps. 117; Ex 15:21). The call to praise can consist of a single verse (Ps 98:1) or several verses (Ps 118:1-4; 135:1-3) and is sometimes repeated in the course of the Psalm (Ps 98:4-8).

The motivation behind the appeal to praise the wonderful deeds of God is often introduced by the conjunction "for (Ps 98:1-9). Sometimes a participated clause may be used (Ps 9:36 and 147).

Thanksgiving songs: these can be individual or communal. Individual songs of thanksgiving relate to the situation of need from which an individual has been saved (1 Sam 2:1-10). It was often possible to combine thanksgiving and praise songs like in cases of Ps. 116 or Jonah 2.

Lament songs – these too can be individual or collective. These songs were recited at moments of great need and during penitential feasts and were accompanied as a rule by periods of fasting (Ps 44, 74, 79, 80, and Joel 2:15-17). The songs served as prayers for the restoration of God's salvific care.

Lament songs exhibit a particular structure that consists of these elements; invocation, lament, confession of trust in God, prayer of entreaty and vow of praise. However the most striking feature of most lament song is the abrupt change of mood. This occurs when there is a sudden shift from lament to thanksgiving (Ps. 6:9-11; 22 23-32; 31:20 ff).

Penitential songs these represent a profound and heartfelt expression of shame and repentance for past sins (Ps 51, Jer 3:23-25 and 14:7-9).

Didactic poems – these songs represent utterances of individual expressed in poetic form. These songs provide the books of Psalms as a whole with its abiding value, offering a point of identification to those who read them in moment of need, struggle and gratitude up to the present day.

Prose

Prose material in the Old Testament offer varied range of form. We can, however, talk of three classifications: legal documents, official records and narrative material.

Legal Material

Most people define the bible as the book of dos and don'ts. They are indirectly referring to the legal materials. The Torah consists of substantial of the legal materials.

Central to the law is the Decalogue. We have two versions of the Decalogue in the Old Testament (Ex 20:1-17 and Deut 5:6-22). The other laws derive their authority from these laws. We read in the Bible that these words were directly communicated by God to Moses. The Biblical writers attaches to the Decalogue.

The oldest forms of the law are present in the "book of the covenant". (Ex 21-23). These laws are of diverse formulation and content.

Generally a distinction is made between two forms: casuistic and apodictic formulations.

Casuistic legal formulations are conditional, i.e., they are dependent on a particular situation. They are introduced by phrases like when, if etc.

Apodictic formulations are prohibitive by nature. (Lev 20:2, Deut 27: 15-26, Ex 22:18). These laws reflect Israel's ancient religious legislation which had its basis in the word of Yhwh.

There laws for most part had to do with the totality of a person's religious and ethical life (Lev 19: 3-4, 11-12 and Lev 19: 13-18).

Jesus summarized the laws into one command of love (15:12; Lev19:18).

Official Records

Official records are mainly lists. These are lists of returnees Babylonian exile (Ezra 2 & Nehemiah 7), list of the builders of the walls of Jerusalem (Nehemiah 3), genealogies (Gen 10) etc.

Questions have been asked regarding the significance of such lists. However, it must be noted that the lists of names in particular with frequent reference to the *op horic* (containing a divine element) personal names, are of extraordinary religious – historical significance, even though they may not be among the most loved segments of the Old Testament.

Other forms of official records are present in annals (2 Sam 8:1-14; 1 Kgs 9:10-28); epistolary literature (Jer 29 & Ezra 4-5) and court order (Ezra 1:2-4).

Narrative Material

Narrative is the important of the prose materials.

Narratives exhibit characteristics of a spoken narration, rather than a purely literary composition. They, for instance, frequently make use of exclamations like “see”, “behold”. This element is meant to call the reader to attention. It is an invitation to the reader to identify with the story.

Another characteristics of the Hebrew narrative is its use of repetition as a means to increase tension. You find in the narrative the main character recounting his experiences (Gen 24; the narrative of the wedding of Rebekah and Isaac). The execution of the already given command tends to be reported in the same words as the command itself (2 Sam 14:24).

A further characteristic of the narrative is that the intention or the purpose of a narrative is often disclosed only in its conclusion. When for example you are dealing with the account of the first fall, it is Gen 3:24 that ends by stating that humans were driven from the garden of Eden and that Cherubs were stationed to prevent them from gaining access to the tree of life; the paradise narrative is thus intended to explain how humans had lost their right of access to the tree of life. Gen 11:9 explains the intention of the narrative of the Tower of Babel: the dispersion of humankind over all the earth.

The actual objective of a narrative can also be stated directly in its opening verses (Gen 22:1).

Old Testament narrative also frequently makes use of word-play which is lost in translation. We read that man was made from clay (*Adam* and *Adamah*), a woman was formed from man (*Issah* and *Ish*), Sara laughed and she gave birth to laughter (Isaac) etc.

The designation narrative is itself a complex term. It contains within itself a variety of other literary forms. We have other forms like; myths which tend to enjoy only a limited place in the Old Testament (Gen 6:1-4). We also have in the Old Testament fold narratives in form of legends related to sanctuaries and prophets together with heroic, nature and tribal sages (Gen 18-19). Judg 13-16 the Samson story.

We find another form of narrative which is found in the biographies and autobiographies. We have examples of biography (Jer. 26-45). Autobiographies include the memoirs of Ezra (Ezra 7 ff) and Nehemiah (Neh 1-2, 4-7).

This part explores the values that we find within the Bible. The section further explores aspects of human calling to stewardship. It leads us on what the Bible says about things like work, justice, freedom, love, leadership etc.

Selected themes in the Bible

WORK

Two basic questions people often ask in relation to work are; why should I work and for whom do I work?

Most people generally work grudgingly because they think work is a product of sin. This though is drawn from the misinterpretation of Gen 3: 17-19. It is important to note that is the only passage in the Bible that portrays work in a negative taste. However, even in this passage what is cursed is the sin of our first parents that poisoned their relationship with their Creator and other creatures. It is because of human sin that work begins to appear like a burden (Gen 3:19).

Work was from the very beginning intended by God. We read in Gen 1-2 that God created human beings in his own image and likeness (Gen 1:27) and he entrusted them with work (Gen 2:15). In Gen 1:28 human beings are commanded to conquer and subdue the earth. One can ask, how else are they to do this if they do not work? In Gen 2:15 God placed human beings in the Garden of Eden to cultivate and to take care of it.

We can say without any fear of contradiction that the Bible is very positive about work. God himself is basically presented as a worker in the Bible. God is a worker because he is the Creator (Gen 14:19; Heb 1:10; 4:4, God makes the heavens with his fingers (Ps 8:4). God is a worker through his continued providence. We read, for example, in Exodus how God rescued Israel from Egypt with mighty hands and uplifted arms. We see him further providing them with manna in the wilderness, cf. Ex 16:4ff.

Human work is consequently therefore a reflection of the Creator's action. God made human beings in his own image (Gen 1:27). Human beings are God's co-partner, or co-creators. When we work it is an extension of God's work.

Human work is by implication a flowering of the creator's action. It is a fulfillment of the divine will. In Gen 1:28 human beings have to be fruitful and fill the earth. Human being have no choice but to labour in order to dominate the earth and subdue it (Ps 104:24; Si 7:15).

Work is, therefore, an essential fundamental fact of human existence. Work is essential for both the development of the world and self (Gen 2:2; Ps 103:22; Isaiah 49:9; Prov 13:1). Ultimately good work humanizes. Human beings find fulfillment when they partake in work.

This explains why the Bible is against idleness. The Bible is very severe to idleness (Prov 13:4; 21:25, 2 Thes 3:10). Idleness is seen as a type of decay. In Prov 31:27 the text admires a woman who is always wide awake and does not eat the bread of idleness (Prov 26:14). In Sir 22:1ff a lazy man is spattered rock. An idler is a burden to himself and stands a risk of dying of starvation, since he will have nothing to eat (Prov 13:4). He is seen as stupid (Prov 24:30).

The Old Testament is highly appreciative of work well done (1 K 7:1-12; Is 40:19 ff; 41:6 ff). God bless the honest toil.

What, therefore, is the purpose of work? We can put it the other way: why should I work?

Work on the face level is primarily for the benefit of human kind. The very first thing God did with Adam was put him in the garden to work for his own benefit. However, it must be noted that what may be good work to the world may be nothing more than filthy rags in God's sight. If it's all about me and God's glory is not seen in my work. The reason for our working must go beyond us. The late Geoffrey Griffins once noted, the world is full of people who do their duty half heartedly, grudgingly and poorly. Do not mind about them. Whatever your duty is, do it as fully and perfectly as you possibly can…. Not for any reward but because it is the right thing to do. 1 Peter provides the ultimate ground for human work; In order that in everything God may be glorified through Jesus Christ to him belong glory and dominion forever and ever (1 Peter 4:11). The ultimate purpose of human work is the manifestation of the glory of God. When we work we are participating in creation. We get engaged in a divine duty. Sin has grossly tarnished the beautiful image of work. In some cases work has become discriminatory and oppressive. Jesus therefore comes as a worker.

Jesus is born in a craftsman's family; he is referred to as the carpenter's son, the lowest of professions.

Jesus in his teachings makes several references to work, in most cases building on the Old Testament. We can for purpose of example mention the following:

- Relationship between employers and employees (Mt 18:23-27)
- Honesty and responsibility in work (Mt 21:28-31
- Reliability at work (Mt 24:45-47
- Joy and cooperation at work (Lk 6:40)
- Keeping balance in work (Lk 12:15)
- The final goal of work is union with God and fellow human beings (John 6:27)
- The entire Jesus' mission is depicted as work (John 10:1ff, 15:1; Mk 2:17; 4:3). It is a work of harvesting (Mt 9:37; Jn 4:38) or fishing (Mt 4:19)

Jesus goes further to transform the understanding of work. Jesus indicates the virtues that go with work. Work ought to be performed in charity and under the principle of brotherhood (Plm). Jesus requires the practice of good works, i.e. we have to work with purity of intentions (Mt 5:16).

Thus work remains the necessary expression of faith (Jam 2:14-26; Eph 2:10; Gal 5:22 ff).

Jesus, therefore, demands a faith that works through charity (Gal 5:6).

It must, however, be noted that a full life demands contraries. When we chase we seek to capture etc. Hence when we work we must also rest. Human being ought to balance between work and rest.

Ex. 20:9 commands people to labour for six days and rest on the Sabbath for on this day Yahweh rested. The rest gives human beings an opportunity to communicate with God and also to restore the lost energy.

We capture three symbolisms related to rest from the Bible.

First, rest is a participation in the divine repose. After the creation of the heavens and earth God rested as sign of who we are; Ex 31:17, Gen 2:2ff Ez 20:12. Human beings need rest to recover self image lest they become transformed into the work itself. We must keep a distinction between the work we do and who we are. Rest gives us the chance of revealing this image of God within us.

Second, rest is a symbol of liberation. In Ex 23:12 the Israelites were instructed to give rest to animals and field labourers on Sabbath as a sign of kindness. Dt 5:15 the Israelites are called to always recall their slavery so that they become liberators not oppressors. Therefore, Sabbath becomes the symbol of liberty.

Third rest is a symbol of celebration. Sabbath is meant for one to turn ones energies to joyfully praise of the creature's redeemer. It a day of thanksgiving in which we ought to find our ultimate goodness. It is a day of delight in which we find Yahweh our delight (Isa 58:13ff).

Finally, we may ask if work and rest are mutually exclusive.

Jesus says in John 5:17 my Father has never ceased working and so do I.

Rest does necessarily mean a stop in work. It implies, as the adage goes, a change is as good as a rest. What we need is to perform our work joyfully for Jesus always offers rest to those who come to him (Mt 11:29).

JUSTICE

In the account of creation in Genesis we are called upon as stewards to act justly and correctly. This call raises the question about what Justice is. Justice is a common word in everyone's lips.

The word is often found in the Bible a long side the word righteousness (Lk 10^9, Ps 33^5). This begs the question whether the two words are interchangeable.

Justice is an action that establishes the right or expresses one's righteousness. Justice entails a fairness, giving a person his or her due. Righteousness goes further, it means a goodness, a kindness or a benevolence.

The prophets are the greatest advocates of Justice. The prophets were shocked by the absence of righteousness and the perversion of Justice (Amos 6^{12}, Jer 8^{14}, 9^{14}, 23^{15}, Hos 10^{4} Prov 5^{4}). The prophets singled out leaders such as Kings, the princess, false prophets and the priests as the ones responsible for the sins of the community. (Hos 4^{6}, 8^{f}, $7^{3,16,}$ 9^{15}, Jer 2^{26}, Is 3^{14-15}).

The doing of Justice was the hallmark of a righteous King of Israel (1 Sam 8^{15}, Ps 7^{21}). It was a proof that he walks in God's wisdom (Lk 3^{28}, Prov 8^{15}). To ignore wisdom and not to know Justice is a foolishness that brings devastating judgment (Prov $29^{2,4}$, Mic ^{3}).

Justice is not for leaders only, it is an integral part of God's law founded upon this holiness. The doing of Justice is a demand of every person and thus it's a supreme commandment. It is the way of the Lord (Gen 18^{18-19}). God demands righteousness of all his people (Jer 9^{23-24}). Justice, righteousness and kindness is God's knowledge.

We can, therefore, talk of Justice as a dominant power, or a life giving substance which is charged with omnipotence of God. It is a manifestation of God. We see that the holy Israel is sanctified in righteousness (Ps 97^{2}, Is 33^{3-5}). God shows his greatness in the rendering of righteousness and mercy (Isa 30^{18}). God finds his true exaltation in Justice. It is a Justice that leads to redemption (Isa 1^{27}). God's concern for Justice grows out of his compassion for persons.

Through righteousness God calls on his people to make a righteous response. The question is how we respond to God's Justice. There are two ways in which we can do this. First is by keeping God's law (Deut 6^{25}) and second by doing Justice. (Deut 24^{10-13}, Job 29^{14-17}). The observance of these two makes us gain life (Ez 18^{5-9}, Hab 2^{4}).

Justice here is much more that just doing your duty. It is an interpersonal relationship implying both a claim and responsibility. One identifies the self with what concerns other individuals or the whole community. It involves both a right and a duty towards God and fellow humans. Abraham was, for example, made into a great nation for the purpose of changing his children and household after him to keep the way of the Lord by doing righteousness and Justice (Gen 18^{18-19}).

The question asked is how do we do Justice?

There are many ways in which we can practice Justice. The common victims of injustice are the poor and the oppressed. It is manifested in the presence of oppression and corruption. Hence the doing of Justice calls for aiding or saving the victims of oppression (Ps 76^{9-10}). This takes the form of:

- ✓ Vindicating the cause of the poor and the oppressed by heeding their cry (Job 29^{12}, Ps 18^{6}).
- ✓ Knowing their rights and being their help (Job 29^{15-17}); Prov 29^{7}).
- ✓ Dealing fairly in marketplace (Deut 24^{10-13})
- ✓ Showing impartiality by not favouring the rich (James 2^{1}-7).
- ✓ Taking care of the hungry, the thirsty and the naked (Mt 25^{31-46}).

In sum, it must be noted that justice is not important for its own sake. It is only valid depending on the blessings it brings to the people. Justice exists in relation to a person and is something done by a person (Ex 22^{22-23}, ^{27}).

The world was not made for the sake of maintaining justice rather justice exists for the sake of maintaining the world.

Failure to do justice is to be blind to God's merciful justice that leads to salvation (Isa 59^{4}, $^{9-11}$, ^{14}; Prov 21^{13}, Jas 2^{13}). The practice of justice is better than sacrifice. Sabbaths and all other religious duties are worthless without it (Is 1^{11-17}, 58^{1ff}, Mt 23^{23}). It is, above all, the proof of the covenant between God and humans.

Love

One of the greatest quest for all humanity is love. As human beings, we have a built in capacity for love alongside our instinctive radar for detecting lover – or lack of it. We know when others love us and sometimes we know what love is by the absence of it. This capacity for love is one of the ways in which we are created in the image of God (Gen 1:27).

Love is one of the essentials of God's nature. God does not only love but God is love. In John 4:8 whoever does not love God does not know him. God's love is always present. A child once asked the father if the father loved him. The father replied, "Yes my son and love you." The son not being satisfied with the general answer went further to inquire, "What about when I do good things?" The father's answer was the same, "I love you." The son again asked, "What about when I do bad things?" The father replied, "I love you." The child got perplexed thinking the father was not being honest. He interrogated the father, "How can you love me when I do good things and still when I do bad things?" The father's reply was, "When you do good things I love you and am proud of you, but when you do bad things I love you but am ashamed of you."

God's love is not dependent on what we do or our responses because love is who God is. It is this context that we can understand Jesus command to love our enemies.

What does love then mean in this context? The English word for love does not fully express the biblical concept of love. In English understanding love is often associated with feelings or emotions. We, therefore, talk about people falling in and out of love.

The Hebrew word for love is used in different contexts:

The word may signify simple sexual attachments (Gen 34:3; Jdgs 16:4, 15; Is 57:8; Jer 2:25; Hos 2:7-15)

The word may also designate a preference. A classical example is the love between David and Saul 1 Sam 16:21, love of a slave to the master (Ex 31:5; Deut 15:16)

Love as friendship: one's friends are one's lovers (1 Sam 18:1; Job 19:19; Jer 20:4;6 2 Sam 1:26 "I am distressed for you, my brother Jonathan; greatly beloved were you to me; your love to me was wonderful, passing the love of women.

Deuteronomy is the first Old Testament document to greatly expound on the idea of love. The book centralizes on the notion of the love of Yahweh. Israel is to love God with whole their heart and whole their strength. The love of Yahweh was manifested in the keeping of his commandments.

In the New Testament, the Greek uses three words for love; *eros*, *philia* and *agape*. *Eros* signifies the passion of sexual desire which does not appear in the NT.

Philia is the primary love of friendship. *Agape* is often rendered in English as charity. It is predominantly a Christian notion.

The New Testament relates the love of God with love of neighbour (Deut 6:5; Lv 19:18 Mt 22:34-40; Mk 12:28-34; Lk 10:25-28). These two form the two sides of the coin, where one is reflection of the other. Here the New Testament revolutionalizes the Old Testament understanding. The concept of neighbour goes far beyond the one of the Old Testament, (one who lives close to you) to encompass one's enemies (Lk 10:29-37), e.g., the parable of Good Samaritan (Mt 5:43-48). Christian love is not dependent upon the behaviour of one's neighbour towards self. Christians have a duty towards loving both friends and foes.

Elaine outlines four natures of this kind of love

- Love extends beyond itself. Love moves out from the one who loves. It is love that led Jesus to die for us on the cross despite our sinfulness.

- Love is dynamic, creating responsive action

Love is best realized in deeds than words. Dynamic love expresses itself in action or control of action. Genuine love desires the best of the other person. Love never desires things for itself 1 Cor 13:4-8.

- Love is costly

There is an erroneous notion that where there is love there is no hurt. The difference is that true love does not mind being hurt. Love creates real. It is through Jesus true love for humanity that made him suffer beating and eventual death on the cross. It is this love that has freed us from the power of fear and death and made us into free people (Heb 2:14-15).

Love as an ever enlarging capacity. The more we know God the more we love. The great example of time of ever growing love is Mother Theresa.

In conclusion we can therefore say that the love of God entails obedience, "if you love me keep my commandments (John 14:15). We also read in John 14:21, "He who has my commandments and keeps them is the one who loves me." We cannot love God with all our heart, mind and soul until we know his command, begin to practice them by walking in his spirit. The journey is in the love of neighbour. Love of fellow means a service toward humanity (Deut 10:12-13, Josh 22:5). One in love must put away all bitterness, wrath, anger, wrangling slander and malice (Eph 4:31). True love is realized in forgiveness (Eph 4:32).

Trust in God (John 14:1), humility (Mt 18:1-4; Lk 18:9-14), and prayer (Mt 6:9-13, Lk 18:1-8) are the components of true love.

Freedom

Freedom is one of the most popular concepts in most people's lips. It is the underlying thought behind a system such as democracy. We can also say freedom is one of the most abused ideology. There are many who believe in boundless freedom, i.e., freedom unto itself.

It, therefore, becomes imperative to seek the biblical understanding of freedom. The Old Testament use of freedom is opposed to slavery to social state. Freedom is opposed to slavery or being a foreigner (Ex 21:2;5, Lev 19:20; Deut 15:12-18, Jer 34:8-17; Job 3:19). It is the ability of being independent or able to dispose. Freedom was greatly treasured no wonder among the three things a male Jew thanked God for was being born, being a Jew and being free. The great experience of the Exodus was also seen in the context of freedom. Israel was ransomed from Egypt to become the servants of God (Lev 25:45; Deut 6:20-25). Freedom in this context is closely linked to redemption (Ex 20:2, Deut 7:8). Hence though God had set Israel free from the slavery from Egypt they remained bound to Yahweh. The loss of their freedom was tied to their desertion of God.

In the eyes of the Old Testament, a free person was a noble person, a person able to control the self, i.e., a generous being. Freedom was, therefore, something to be yearned for. In Is 61:1 the messiah will come to proclaim freedom to the captives.

Deuteronomy emphasizes freedom within the Decalogue in the context of the Sabbath commandment (Deut 5:15). The Israelite must celebrate the Sabbath with the memory that once they were slaves in Egypt. The implication is that they ought to become liberators and not oppressors. Hence the Decalogue greatly advocates for the freedom of both the servants and animals. Deuteronomy also offers a protection for an escapee slave from his former master (Deut 25:15f).

The New Testament advances the understanding of freedom from a social aspect to spiritual one. The greatest contributor on freedom is Paul. Paul holds that Christians have been called to a life of freedom. A Christian is free from sin, death and the law.

Christ had to free us from sin because it had enslaved by forcing us to look inward. Sin stops us from service by making us egocentric (2 Pet 2:19). A believer must, therefore, continue with the struggle against evil (Rom 6:12,19; 1 Cor 6:18 ff). The emanating freedom means giving no room to sin (Rom 6:12). Hence to be free is living for Christ.

So freedom is in Christ (Gal 2:4). Christian freedom has to do with finding the truth in Jesus Christ and being liberated. It is Christ who sets us free (Gal 5).

A free person is therefore, one who lives according to the intended will of God (Jos 1:25). Human freedom is in the life with God (Rom 6:22, Gal 5:1, 13; 1 Pet 2:16). Paul, therefore, happily proclaims it is no longer I who lives but Christ who lives in me.

Consequently a free person does not live for the self (1 Cor 16:19; 1 Pet 2:16). The person must follow after the example of the master who died for us (2 Cor 5:15). Freedom means putting others first. Paul notes in 1 Cor 8 in the issue of meat offered to idols if the eating of meat makes my brother sin then I will never eat meat again.

Freedom is attained in truth (Jh 8:32). Thus when we are liberated then we can serve God (Jas 1:25; 2:12). The chief task of Christ was to liberate us from fear. The freedom which we have attained leads us to true humanity. True humanity will only be attained when we are declared righteous (1 Thes 1:9). It is in this breath that Luther holds, "A Christian is perfectly free lord of all, subject to none. A Christian is perfectly dutiful servant of all, subject to all (Martin Luther 1961:53). Christian service is characterized by love (Gal 5:22; 1 Cor 9:19ff).

LEADERSHIP

The greatest crisis in the world today is a crisis of leadership. World over there is in a persistent cry over leadership. Today we are at stage where there is uproar in Arab world over its leaders.

It can consequently be stated that the greatest crisis in leadership is a crisis of character. The world greatly lacks value oriented leaders. There is an increasing out cry for role models.

It is time to go to the basics like the Bible for an induction on leadership. Someone might ask, why the Bible? The Bible remains probably the greatest resource for leadership ever written. We learn from the Bible the foundation, purpose and nature of leadership.

The biblical text sees God as the foundation of human leadership. We can have nothing unless it is given to us. Leadership is, therefore, a form of stewardship. It implies that all forms of dictatorial tendencies are not tolerated in the Bible since leaders have to account for their conduct. Leadership must mirror God. God's leadership is the best form of leadership.

It implies the need for consultation since leadership is given. Leaders must consent with the giver who happens to be God. Good listening becomes a condition for a good leader. The person must listen to God in prayer. Other than God we must consult with fellow people. It is often said, the voice of the people is the voice of God. Leadership is for and about the community, so it is paramount to access the feelings of the people. In Exodus 18, Jethro advises Moses to work with others in solving issues of the people. In I Chronicles 13-14, David acts in consultation with the people.

However, at the core of biblical leadership there is service. Jesus noted he was a among us as one who serves (Mt 20:26-28). The bible advocates for servant leadership model. Jesus is the one who washed the feet of his disciples (John 1:38). It means that a leader does not put himself first but last. When put in other words, when offered a cup of tea to a good officer, he won't take it until his men are settled down with cups of their own.

A leader thus by implication must lead from the front. A leader does not say, "Advance boys but follow me." A leader is front up, takes the blame but not the glory and sees the good of all. Selfish interests have no room in good leadership.

The world today is increasingly challenging us to transformational leadership. It is a form of leadership where the character becomes the main component. It is realized that we transform people more through our behavior than the giver.

It is important to list some of the characteristics expected of a leader.

Humility: - It is the ability of self emptying (*kenosis*) it is the best capacity of leadership because it is a behavior that creates unity. Paul affirms that he became a Jew and to Greek a Greek. This behavior is best exampled in Christ who took human nature for our sake Ph 2:5-11

Compassion: Generally the word is understood in terms of feelings of sympathy towards other people. The action of compassion in the Bible points to a deeper meaning. It is having power but using it for the sake of others. It is a lack of preoccupation with powerful images. Jesus throughout his ministry shows acts of compassion by feeding the hungry and healing the sick **(Mt. 9:36, 14:14, 15:32, Mk 6:34, Lk 15:20).** In the story of the good Samaritan we see a compassionate act of the good Samaritan. Jesus never used power for self gain best illustrated in his temptation. This understanding is best illustrated in a Rwandese saying that, its not where you are but what you do there that matters or in a Greek proverb that the measure of a man is in what he does with power.

Influence: We are today geared towards a visionary leadership. This calls for working with imagination, insight and boldness. It calls for a person who views the horizon, not just the near end at hand, a person who would see the bigger picture and serve the good of the whole. It means you must be value filled person. It is a call to commitment. The Ugandans say that he who does not know where he is going will not know where and when he arrives. In Mt. 5, we learn that leaders are the "…the light of the world." Hence they must be directed by great vision. **(Prov. 29:18).** It is to say that a leader takes people where they want to go but a great leader takes people where they do not want to go but where they ought to be.

Wisdom: It is often said that distinction is the mother of learning. When we can distinguish between things then we have learnt. We become wise, i.e., we have the capacity of realizing what is of value in life for oneself and for others. We know what the creator requires (**Mich. 6:8).**

Integrity: It is often likened to faithfulness. It is a consistency of action that creates wholeness or completeness **(Prov. 28:6, Titus 2:7).** It provides a sense of security/reliability. Samuel was so trusted by the people because of his integrity (**1 Samuel 12:1-4).**

Honesty: It has been put forward as the best policy. William Shakespeare noted that, no legacy is so rich as honesty. It is about being truthful, authentic or real. It is virtue that leads us to responsibility (**1 Timothy 2:3).**

Patience: It is the quality of endurance or forbearance. It is one of the most valuable virtues of life. In the Bible, it is frequently represented virtue (Prov. 25:14-16, Eccl 7:7-9, Thess 5:14-15, Gal 5:21-23). It portrays a character of steadfastness and seeks the good of all. A good leader is not self powered, self-centered (Num 11:26-30, Mk 9:38-41, Ph 1:18. Patient leadership develops others in future leaders. There exists no fear of other Members as …….

Just: A behavior of relationship that calls on people to be sensitive to others